

Responses to Sources Sought Notice IHS_SS_26_0406 Questions

Responses are provided below for informational and market research purposes only.

1. Can you supply additional details of the existing system that is in place?

The current Joslin Vision Network (JVN) system is a highly specialized, integrated teleophthalmology platform that includes software and hardware for image acquisition, secure transmission, storage, and interpretation, as well as a centralized reading and reporting capability. The system supports remote diagnosis of diabetic retinopathy over a nationally distributed network of over 120 sites and is integrated into existing Indian Health Service (IHS) clinical and IT infrastructure.

2. Are we to choose and deliver the platform that can be used in order to replace the existing system? Or are you looking specifically for support of the current environment?

The Government is currently assessing industry capabilities to support the continued operation of the existing system. The final acquisition approach has not yet been determined. Any potential approach must ensure continuity of operations and avoid disruption of critical teleophthalmology services currently deployed across a nationwide network of sites. Vendors proposing alternative approaches should clearly address their ability to meet these requirements, including transition timelines, system compatibility, and associated risks.

3. Are there specific technical requirements that are needed to be met with the platform that you are looking for?

Please reference the requirements provided in the Sources Sought Notice.

4. Certain equipment is named in the document, is that a comprehensive list or is there any additional equipment that is required to be supported?

The major equipment necessary for the current operational configuration is outlined in the Sources Sought Notice.

5. Please provide guidance on the formal definition of “telehealth” as used by IHS in the context of this requirement.

For purposes of this requirement, telehealth refers to the use of telecommunication technologies to support the remote acquisition, transmission, interpretation, and reporting of retinal images within the IHS teleophthalmology program.

6. Please provide guidance on any distinctions between telehealth, telemedicine, teleophthalmology, and teleretinal services within IHS programs.

Telehealth and telemedicine are terms encompassing a range of remote clinical services. Teleophthalmology and teleretinal refer to specific services that the program provides, focused on retinal imaging to diagnose diabetic retinopathy and provide interpretation, follow-up recommendations, and reporting to originating sites. In addition, other identified retinal conditions are included in the reporting. The IHS-JVN Teleophthalmology program is a category 3 telemedicine program and any vendor providing services must be able to maintain this level of service.

7. Please provide guidance on whether “telehealth services” in this notice encompass only clinical image acquisition and interpretation, or also include supporting functions such as training, analytics, AI-assisted diagnostics, and patient management workflows.

The requirements include the functions necessary to support the teleophthalmology system, including image acquisition, secure transmission, storage, interpretation, reporting, and associated operational support such as system maintenance, equipment support, and user training. The program operates as a reader-dependent Category 3 telemedicine program. AI is currently being developed within the program and continued support and development is required.

8. Please provide guidance on any applicable standards, policy references, or governing frameworks IHS uses to define and categorize these services.

The system operates in accordance with applicable federal and IHS requirements related to clinical care, privacy, and information security. In addition, the teleophthalmology program operates consistent with established clinical standards for diabetic retinopathy screening, including those aligned with the American Telemedicine Association (ATA) guidelines for a category 3 store-and-forward telehealth services.